

The Confederates react

Despairing over the series of defeats in Missouri and Arkansas, Jefferson Davis reorganized the command structure of the Trans-Mississippi Department in the spring of 1863, giving overall command to General Edmund Kirby Smith. But before Smith could gather sufficient forces to challenge the Federals, they had marched quickly toward Little Rock, the Arkansas capital.

General Blunt, with a small Union army of 3,000, had entered the Indian Territory in April 1863 and reestablished a post at Fort Gibson, briefly held by the Union in 1861. After reoutfitting his men, he planned to march on Little Rock as part of a pincer strategy focused on the Arkansas capital. The Confederates, however, were not going to give him that opportunity. Brigadier General Douglas Cooper collected about 6,000 troops at Honey Springs, a Rebel outpost some 20 miles (32km) southwest of Fort Gibson, and awaited only the arrival of another 3,000 to launch an attack on Blunt. Cooper's men were badly armed—only 75 percent of them had serviceable firearms, many of these being old smoothbore guns. They also had only four artillery pieces. But the Texas cavalry and Cooper's Choctaw and Chickasaw regiments had high morale and were aching for a fight. Blunt, now well aware of the danger if the two Confederate commands united, launched a preemptive attack on Cooper on July 17. Outnumbered two to one, Blunt's multiracial command was composed of a Black regiment, some Unionist American Indian units, and white regiments from the Midwest. As one historian put it, it was "the first rainbow coalition." Blunt's men were almost all armed with the rifled Springfield musket and had good artillery. For the first half of the battle, which lasted four hours, their technological advantage was nullified by the Rebel numbers and terrain. A determined midday assault by the 1st Kansas Colored Infantry against the center of the Confederate line, however, forced the outgunned Southern artillery to withdraw, and with it the rest of Cooper's force.

Though Honey Springs would be the largest battle ever fought in the Indian Territory, in terms of casualties the engagement was